The `graphicnovel` Class How-To Manual

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1 Purpose

The `graphicnovel` class is a small LaTeX language for writing and validating graphic-novel scripts. The manuscript describes what things *are*; the class handles numbering, formatting, continuity checks, and output.

The project is intentionally split into two kinds of material:

- **Manuscript**: vignettes, comic pages, panels, dialogue, action, layout.
- **Reference bible**: canonical characters, locations, props, expressions, tells, and continuity rules.

The How-To manual is documentation for the class and is separate from both.

2 Recommended project structure

```
project/
  graphicnovel.cls
  bible.tex
  how-to-manual.tex
  reference-bible.tex
  manuscript/
    sworn.tex
    pride.tex
  bible/
    characters.tex
    locations.tex
    props.tex
    continuity.tex
```

A top-level `bible.tex` can simply input the four bible files.

3 Starting a manuscript

```
\documentclass{graphicnovel}
\input{bible}

\begin{document}

\newVignette{Sworn}
\era{2002--2009}

\newComicPage[27]
\pageLayout{2,2}

\newPanel
\location{The Study}
\shot{Wide.}
\action{The BUILDER sits in the chair holding a Bible.}
\dialogue{Builder}{A Bible?}

\end{document}
```

4 Vignettes and page numbering

4.1 Starting a vignette

Use:

```
\newVignette{Sworn}
```

`\newStory` remains available as an alias, but `\newVignette` is the preferred name.

Starting a new vignette does *not* reset the comic-page counter. Comic pages run continuously through the book.

4.2 Starting a comic page

```
\newComicPage
```

increments the comic-page counter and resets the panel counter to zero.

To seed an imported or existing section at a specific page number:

```
\newComicPage[27]
```

The next `\newComicPage` will then become page 28.

If one comic page takes more than one physical sheet of script, later physical sheets automatically receive a `PAGE n (CONTINUED)` header.

5 Page layouts

5.1 Grid-like layouts

The layout grammar describes the number of panels in each horizontal band.

```
\pageLayout{2,2}
```

means two rows, each containing two panels.

```
\pageLayout{4,1,1,1}
```

means four panels across the first band, followed by three full-width panels. The class expects seven panels.

```
\pageLayout{4,4,4,4}
```

means four rows of four panels: sixteen panels total.

5.2 Unequal row heights

Optional heights may be recorded:

```
\pageLayout[heights={2,1,1}]{4,1,1}
```

The class records the intended proportions and still validates the expected panel count.

5.3 Irregular layouts

For pages that cannot sensibly be expressed as rows:

```
\customLayout[panels=6]{
  Large central panel with five inset panels around it.
}
```

The geometry itself is free-form, but the panel count is still checked.

6 Double-page spreads

A double-page spread is treated as one image spanning two consecutive comic pages. It does not need `\pageLayout` or `\newPanel`.

To begin a spread at a known page number:

```
\newDoublePageSpread[12]
\location{Jacobean House Exterior}
\shot{Wide shot, framed over a thorny bramble branch.}
\action{
  A crumbling Jacobean house with obvious damage and a drive.
  The house does not fill the frame. It is night under a full moon.
  Stark white lights show only on the ground floor.
}
\noDialogue
\noCaptions
\turnTo{14}
```

This produces `PAGE 12/13 -- DOUBLE PAGE SPREAD`. Internally pages 12 and 13 are consumed, so the next ordinary:

```
\newComicPage
```

becomes page 14 automatically.

If the optional start number is omitted:

```
\newDoublePageSpread
```

the spread begins on the next comic page and consumes that page plus the following one. The short alias `\newSpread` is also available.

Because facing-page spreads normally begin on an even-numbered left page, the class warns if a spread starts on an odd comic page. This is a warning rather than an error because unusual pagination may be intentional.

`\noDialogue` and `\noCaptions` explicitly print those production instructions. If dialogue or a caption is also supplied on the same page, validation reports the contradiction.

`\turnTo{14}` prints `TURN TO PAGE 14`. On a double-page spread the class knows what the next page should be and warns if the number is inconsistent.

Do not use `\newPanel` inside a double-page spread: the spread itself is the single spanning image.

7 Panels

Start each panel with:

```
\newPanel
```

The panel counter increments automatically.

A typical panel is:

```
\newPanel
\location{The Study}
\shot{Medium two-shot.}
\action{The BUILDER watches the NARRATOR carefully.}
\dialogue{Builder}{Go on.}
\sfx{Tap Tap Tap}
```

7.1 Panel directives

Directive	Meaning
`\location{...}`	Canonical location. Checked against the bible.
`\sameLocation`	Explicitly reuse the preceding panel's location.
`\shot{...}`	Framing, viewpoint, or composition.
`\action{...}`	What the artist sees happening.
`\dialogue{Character}{...}`	Dialogue; character checked against bible.
`\dialogue[off]{Character}{...}`	Off-panel dialogue.
`\dialogue[position=...]{...}{...}`	Adds balloon-placement guidance.
`\caption{...}`	Caption box.
`\sfx{...}`	Sound effect.
`\note{...}`	Exceptional artist or letterer instruction.
`\expression{CHAR}{NAME}`	Named expression from the character bible.
`\tell{CHAR}{NAME}`	Named physical tell from the character bible.

A panel should normally contain a location and at least one of `shot` or `action`. Missing values generate warnings.

8 The reference bible

The bible is loaded before `\begin{document}`:

```
\input{bible}
```

Entries both store descriptive material and register canonical names for validation.

8.1 Characters

```
\begin{character}{Narrator}
  \aka{The Bastard}
  \height{6'2"}
  \ageRange{24 to early 50s}
  \appearance{Dark eyes, olive skin, dark unruly hair.}
  \wardrobe{Starts fashionable and becomes practical.}
  \charfield{What he is not}{Not a romance lead.}
  \expression{RELISH}{Combat is delicious.}
  \tell{THE PAUSE}{A deliberate performance before brutality.}
\end{character}
```

Available character-specific fields include:

- `\aka`

- \height
- \ageRange
- \appearance
- \wardrobe
- \charfield{Label}{Text}
- \characterparagraph{Text}
- \expression{Name}{Description}
- \tell{Name}{Description}

Inside a character entry, \expression and \tell define named visual assets. In the manuscript, the same commands take *character + name* and validate use.

8.2 Locations

```
\begin{locationentry}{The Study}
  \introducedIn{Sworn}
  \locfield{Type}{Permanent recurring set}
  \architecture{Desk before the window; hallway visible.}
  \furniture{Cherrywood pedestal desk and full-wall bookcase.}
  \lighting{Green-shaded sconces and banker's lamp.}
  \technology{Sun Ultra 5, Sun CRT, stacked SCSI disks.}
  \continuityRule{The desk must retain a sightline to the hallway.}
  \mood{Old-fashioned, comfortable, slightly clubby.}
\end{locationentry}
```

Available location directives include:

- \introducedIn
- \architecture
- \furniture
- \lighting
- \technology
- \continuityRule
- \mood
- \locfield{Label}{Text}
- \locationparagraph{Text}

8.3 Props

```
\begin{propentry}{The Bible}
  \introducedIn{Sworn}
  \propfield{Type}{Recurring prop}
  \propparagraph{A standard Bible used for the oath joke.}
  \continuityRule{In the HR panel it sits under the narrator's hand.}
\end{propentry}
```

Use \propfield for arbitrary labelled information and \propparagraph for prose.

8.4 Continuity items

Continuity entries hold facts that apply across scenes or eras rather than belonging to one character, place, or prop.

```
\begin{continuityitem}{The Clock}
  \continuityparagraph{
    The BUILDER is weathered; the NARRATOR is worn.
  }
  \continuityfield{Fixed anchors}{
    Hotel, 1988 (N 24 / B 31). Shoo!, 1994 (N 30 / B 37).
  }
  \continuityfield{2002--2009}{
    Narrator approximately 38--45; Builder approximately 45--52.
  }
  \technology{Visible technology must match the vignette's era.}
\end{continuityitem}
```

Typical continuity items include *The Clock*, technology timeline, vehicles by era, renovation chronology, relationship chronology, or who knows what when.

9 Printing the reference bible

The bible can be compiled independently of the manuscript.

```
\documentclass{graphicnovel}
\input{bible}

\begin{document}
\section*{Reference Bible}
\printReferenceBible
\end{document}
```

Individual sections are also available:

```
\printCharacterBible
\printLocationBible
\printPropBible
\printContinuityBible
```

10 Validation

The class currently checks:

- page layout declared;
- actual panel count matches the layout;
- panel has a location;
- panel has either a shot or action;
- character names are known;
- location names are known;
- expressions belong to the stated character;
- tells belong to the stated character;

- double-page spreads consume exactly two comic-page numbers;
- a spread beginning on an odd page generates a facing-page warning;
- `NO DIALOGUE` / `NO CAPTIONS` declarations do not contradict supplied material;
- a spread's `TURN TO PAGE` number matches the next page.

Names are matched case-insensitively, so `Builder`, `BUILDER`, and `builder` resolve to the same declared character. Misspellings still generate warnings.

11 Daily-use cheat sheet

```
\newVignette{Sworn}
\era{2002--2009}

\newComicPage
\pageLayout{4,1,1,1}

\newPanel
\location{The Study}
\shot{Wide.}
\action{...}
\expression{Narrator}{RELISH}
\tell{Builder}{THE TAP}
\dialogue{Narrator}{...}
\caption{...}
\sfx{...}
\note{...}

% Double-page spread:
\newDoublePageSpread[12]
\location{Jacobean House Exterior}
\shot{Wide.}
\action{...}
\noDialogue
\noCaptions
\turnTo{14}
```